

THE HYBRID EDGE Best of Both Worlds

- Internal programmes build organisational “muscle”; external learning stretches mindset
- Creates leaders who are both strategically grounded and enterprise-minded

THE EVOLVING MODEL OF LEADERSHIP

- In-house institutes like Mahindra Leadership University focus on contextual, business-integrated learning anchored in real priorities like AI, inclusion, and sustainability
- Partnerships with top B-schools bring academic rigor and global thought leadership

challenges,” says Bhoola. “External coaches challenge assumptions, create safe spaces, and help uncover hidden potential. While they take longer to understand organisational context, their independence often leads to more candid feedback and deeper transformation.”

She adds that many organisations now adopt a hybrid approach.

Jha agrees that one-on-one executive coaching has become a powerful engagement tool, often running parallel to structured programmes.

In India, learning also extends beyond the individual. “Many executives see learning as a family journey. Programmes that include partners meaningfully, not as social add-ons but as part of the develop-

mental process, deliver richer, more sustainable outcomes,” she notes.

DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD

Technology has shifted from delivery tool to design principle.

The first wave of AI in executive education focused on administrative functions. The second is transformational, using data to create hyper-personalised learning pathways based on each executive’s role, aspirations, and learning style.

“AI is making executive education deeply personal, shifting it from one-size-fits-all to journeys that adapt to how each leader learns and evolves,” says Jha.

Kulkarni adds that IIM Bangalore is reimagining executive education to be immersive and adaptive. “Executives engage in live cases, simulation exercises, and design thinking workshops that address AI-driven and geopolitical disruptions.”

Yet, as Jha cautions, “Technology can enhance, not replace the human element of leadership learning. Executives still value the lived experience of mentors and peers far more than interactions with devices.”

BEYOND BOUNDARIES

As leaders progress, their learning must evolve from internal understanding to external benchmarking.

“The debate between company-specific leadership development and cross-industry exposure presents a false dichotomy,” says Jha. “The most effective journeys blend both, each deployed strategically at different stages of growth.”

Early-career leaders benefit from company-specific learning to understand culture and processes before seeking external perspectives.

The M&M spokesperson agrees: “We cultivate diversity of thought by bringing together leaders across

group companies. This cross-pollination of perspectives, supported by peer coaching and action learning, produces leaders who are both strategic and enterprise-minded.”

THE LIVED CLASSROOM

For Sundeep Talwar, CEO, Impact Guru Foundation, a non-profit organisation, executive education has never been about credentials, it’s about perspective. “After years of leading through complex challenges, I felt the need to reorient myself not just as a CXO, but as a lifelong learner committed to building more empathetic leaders,” he says.

Having attended programmes at Ashoka University and Harvard, Talwar calls them “a crucible of lived experience,” where every case study reflected real-world dilemmas. “Humility and empathy are not soft skills, they’re strategic assets,” he adds.

For Sonal Arora, Country Manager, Gi Group Holding a staffing solutions company, learning has been an ongoing journey. “My first business school experience was a bridge between academics and the corporate world, but my approach to leadership was truly shaped through experience,” she says. Returning for an executive MBA decades later reaffirmed her belief.

She reiterates that in today’s dynamic business environment, continuous skilling and upskilling are crucial to stay relevant.

“Corporate programmes are focused and immediately applicable, while external executive courses offer a broader, exploratory experience. Together, they provide a balanced leadership approach grounded in context and open to growth,” she says.

Leaders who keep learning are the one who keep leading. **BT**